

Revolutionary Guerrilla Warfare

After World War II, guerrilla warfare of the kind practiced by the Viet Minh in Indochina came to be seen not just as a threat to European colonial powers but also as a major challenge to American interests worldwide.

◀◀ BEFORE

Guerrilla warfare has been used to fight powerful adversaries for centuries, including in the American Revolution and World War II.

TRIED AND TESTED

The first description of guerrilla strategy was written by the Chinese general Sun Tzu more than 2,500 years ago. During the **American Revolution**, militias employed guerrilla warfare against the British in South Carolina. In 19th-century Europe, Italian nationalist **Giuseppe Garibaldi** and his Redshirts also fought a guerrilla campaign to unify Italy.

WORLD WAR II

Resistance fighters in Nazi-occupied Europe employed **guerrilla tactics** against occupying forces with the support of Britain and the United States.

In revolutionary guerrilla warfare, irregular forces use guerrilla tactics—ambushes, raids, hit-and-run attacks, concealment, and mobility—in pursuit of the goals of political and social revolution. When the Viet Minh embarked on a guerrilla war against the French in 1946, they were following a path already laid out in theory and practice by Mao Zedong's communists in China.

The Marxist theory, to which communists subscribed, had originally anticipated a revolution based on a revolt by industrial workers in urban areas. Mao envisaged a communist revolution resulting from a guerrilla war based in the countryside. According to Mao's theory, guerrillas would establish themselves in remote areas and use propaganda to win popular support among the peasantry. Their military tactics would progress from scattered raids, ambushes, and sabotage by small-scale forces to larger-scale operations exploiting the mobility of guerrilla forces. Finally, full-scale military operations with heavy weaponry would allow them to defeat the enemy in the field. This scenario was broadly enacted in the process that brought Mao to power in China in 1949.

Although Vo Nguyen Giap, the key organizer of the Viet Minh military rebellion, was reluctant to acknowledge his debt to the Chinese example, his conduct of the war against France and later against the United States clearly showed Mao's influence. The Viet Minh's strategic concept of *dau tranh* (struggle) envisaged a long-term conflict in which military and political pressure would combine to wear down the enemy.